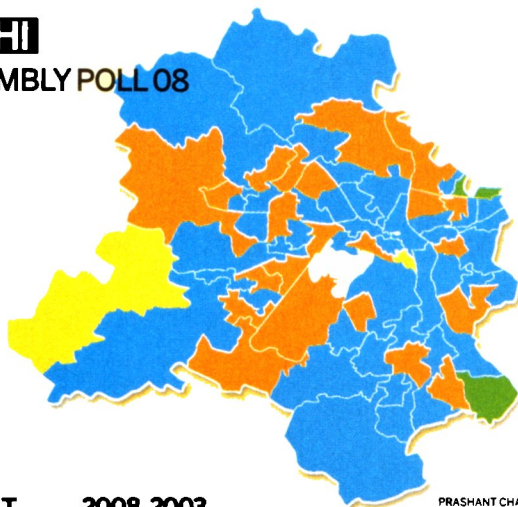


DELHI

ASSEMBLY POLL 08



PRASHANT CHAUDHARY

RESULT	2008	2003
■ CONG	42	47
■ BJP	23	20
■ BSP	02	0
OTHERS	01	02

* Total number of seats: 70

1
out of 7 Lok
Sabha seg-
ments is all
the BJP led in

64
rallies in all
and 250 km
daily clocked
by Dikshit

The BJP failed to capitalise on a 10-year anti-incumbency and made a tactical error both in its chief ministerial candidate and the tone of its campaign.

THE D COMPANY



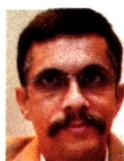
MOHSINA KIDWAI

She was given charge of the Delhi polls but unlike other general secretaries gave Dikshit a free hand in ticket distribution.



J.P. AGGARWAL

For once the chief minister had a supportive PCC chief. Aggarwal helped Dikshit handle the rebels after ticket distribution.



PAWAN KHERA

Dikshit's political secretary for the last 10 years helped in candidate selection and strategising her campaign.



YASBANT NEGI

(FROM LEFT) JAITLEY, HARSHVARDHAN AND MALHOTRA

is too sharp to become a factotum leader. Instead she is a vital link between Indira's Congress and the Rahul era.

The 71-year-old veteran has no time for political games. Instead she wants to work on the Commonwealth Games since it was the development card that worked for her, not to mention the negative tone of the BJP's campaign. "They tried to play up the Mumbai attacks. It would've worked had they not politicised it," she told INDIA TODAY.

Apart from running one of the worst ad campaigns in electoral history, it was the BJP's choice of chief ministerial candidate that boomeranged. Pitting the 78-year-old taciturn V.K. Malhotra against Dikshit's charm was a tactical mistake. Most BJP leaders agree. Malhotra was not the party's first choice. It was only after the more winnable Sushma Swaraj and Arun Jaitley refused that the party chose him. However, Jaitley offered to take charge of the

party's campaign, hoping to add another notch to his 'winning touch'. Such was the arrogance of the BJP leadership that it felt that after a 10-year anti-incumbency, the capital was theirs for the asking. It offered no agenda of its own but merely focused on criticising the Congress. Both the master strategist and the strategy failed. Even now a shocked BJP cannot come to terms with the defeat.

Unlike Malhotra, Dikshit was given a free hand by the Central leadership. This kind of freedom is only given in the Congress when someone is being set up for a fall, like what happened to Digvijay Singh in 2003. Barring son Sandeep, no other MP campaigned extensively for the party. He did his mother proud by delivering eight of the 10 assembly segments in East Delhi. Both Sandeep and her political secretary Pawan Khera came to be known as Dikshit's fix-it boys as they helped strategise her win.

If Dikshit had lost, she would have probably been made general secretary and spent the rest of her political tenure playing *durbar* politics. But the optics of controlling the capital sends a powerful image to the party cadre and Delhi's decisive win was even more of a morale booster for the party than Rajasthan. However, she was careful not to play this as a personal coup saying, "What am I without the Congress?"

That was a smart move. Refusing a bite from a calorie-rich chocolate was another. Not one to let her guard down even for a day, she quizzed well-wishers who crowded the wooden floor on her living room, "Show me the mark on your finger. Did you vote?" She is too seasoned to take anyone for granted. Third time plucky. ■